Exposure, Identity, and Influence: Rethinking Media Effects in the Age of Media Choice

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Persuasion vs Reinforcement

"In high-choice media environments, persuasion may be rare; but identity reinforcement may be pervasive."

Media Effects

Classic Media Effects Model

- Exposure treated as *exogenous*
- Individuals receive information
- Information leads to attitude updating

High-Choice Media Environment

- Individuals actively select what to consume
- Selection shaped by prior attitudes and identities
- Algorithms amplify engagement-consistent content
- networks structure visibility
- Exposure is not independent of prior beliefs

Brexit as a Stress Test

- Not merely a vote.
- A catalyst for debates about political communication, social media, and democratic resilience.
- An identity crystallisation event.
- Producing durable fractures within parties, government, and the electorate.

Outline

RESEARCH QUESTIONS

MEDIA LANDSCAPE

PAPER 1

PAPER 2

DISCUSSION & QUESTIONS

Research Questions

Does media exposure affect ...

Research Questions

Does media exposure affect ...

- voting behaviour?

Research Questions

Does media exposure affect ...

- voting behaviour?
- social identity?

Research Questions

Does media exposure affect ...

- voting behaviour?
- social identity?

... with evidence from Brexit and the subsequent general elections.

What does “media effect” even mean?

Common narratives in the literature:

- Classic media effects theory $\rightarrow$ persuasion
- Psychological models $\rightarrow$ motivated reasoning
- High-choice media environment $\rightarrow$ self-selection
- Online & social media $\rightarrow$ algorithmic filters & curation

Theoretical Frameworks

- Cognitive dissonance (Festinger, 1962)
- Motivated reasoning (Kunda, 1990)
- Selective exposure (Klapper, 1960; Lipset et al., 1954)
- Social identity theory (Tajfel and Turner, 1979)
- etc.

Research Question

RQ: "Under conditions of high media choice and information abundance, what forms of influence, if any, still occur?"

Research Question = set of smaller questions

- Does news consumption predict Brexit vote choice?
- Does it predict identity strength (Leave/Remain)?
- Are effects conditional on prior identity?
- Do different media types operate differently?

Why bother? What changed?

Over the past 12 years, news consumption has shifted dramatically. (Newman et al. (2025))

- Television news audiences declined from 79% to 48%
- Print news readership fell from 59% to 12%

$\rightarrow$ *The UK now has a predominately online, mobile-first news environment.*

Mass Media

- Media landscape is changing, with Online media rising
- Internet facilitates a high-choice media environment (Van Aelst et al., 2017)
- Some academics express worry regarding the rising ideological segregation among the public, attributed to novel technological shifts in the consumption of online media (Anderson, 2006; Adamic and Glance, 2005; Bozdag and Hoven, 2015; Conover et al., 2011; Sunstein, 2009, 2017).

Sources of News in the UK

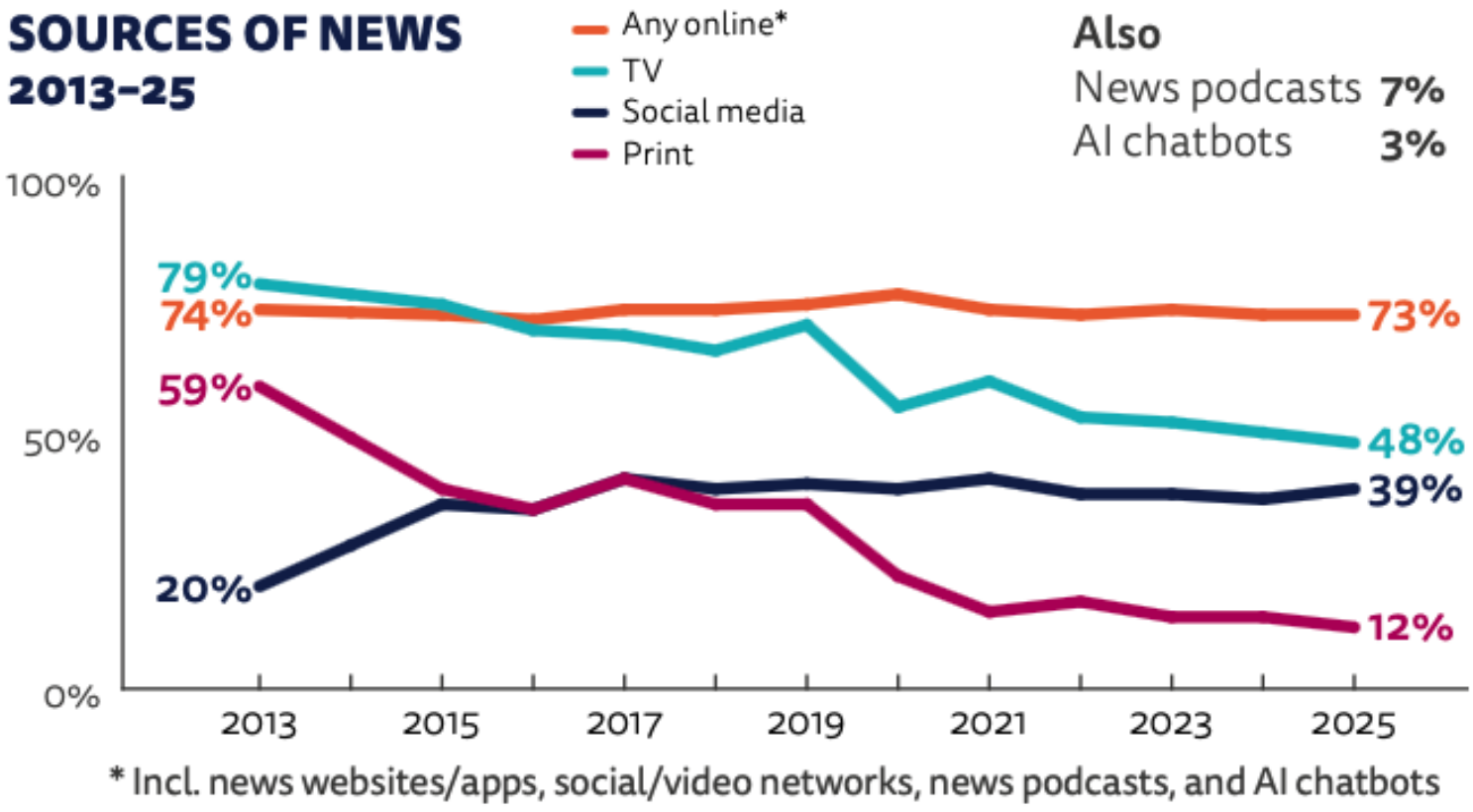


Figure: Newman et al., 2025

Sources of News in the UK

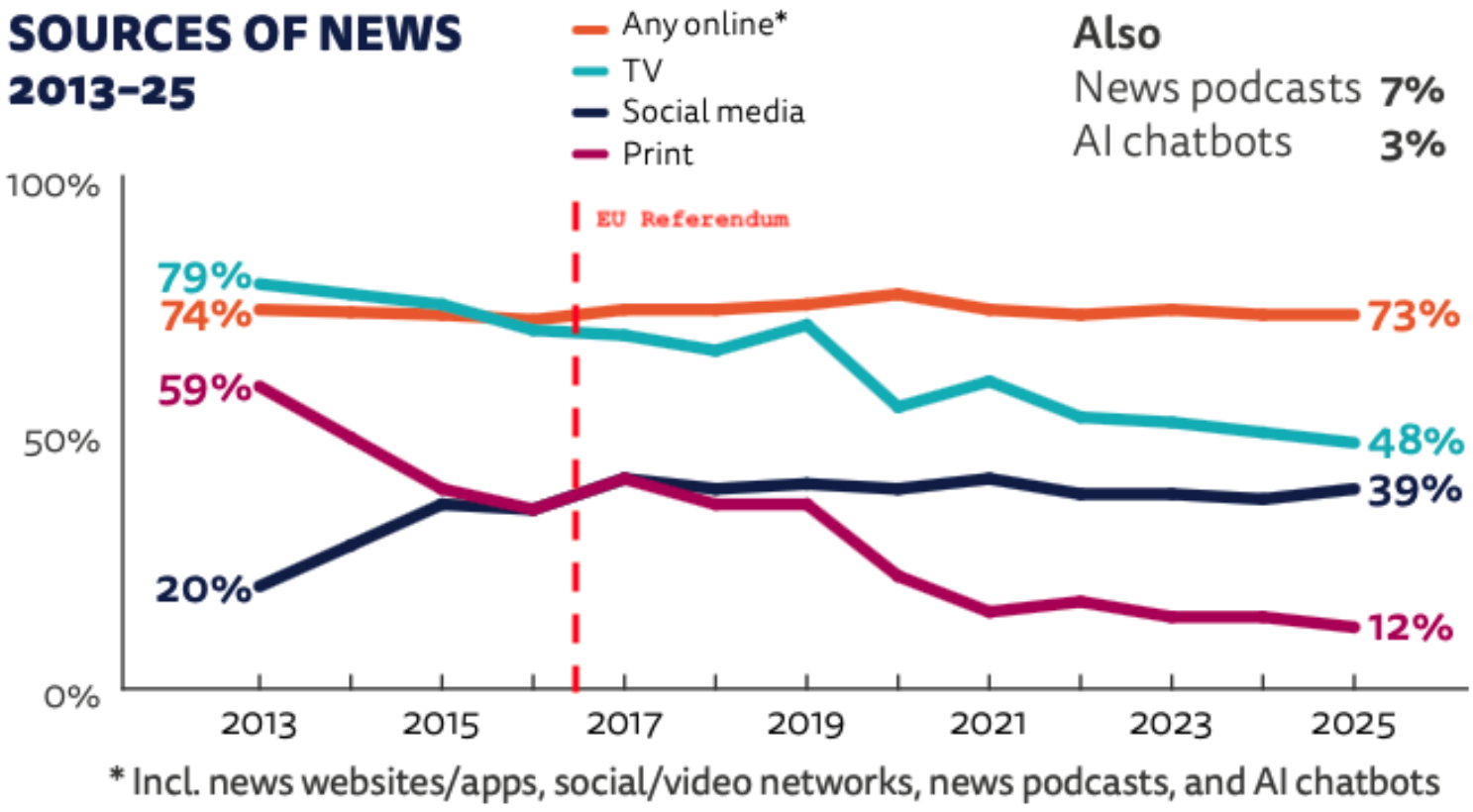


Figure: Newman et al., 2025

Devices for News in UK

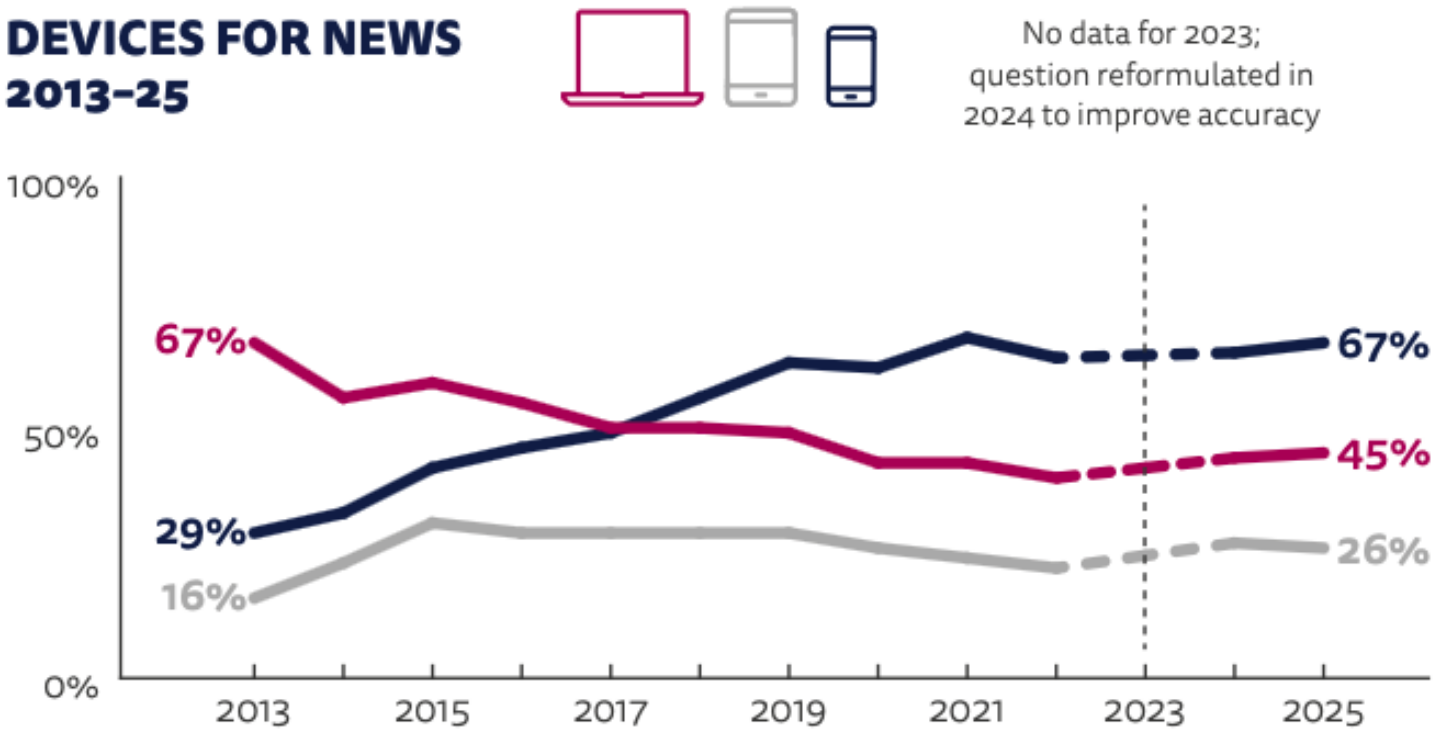


Figure: Newman et al., 2025

Media Consumption and Age in UK

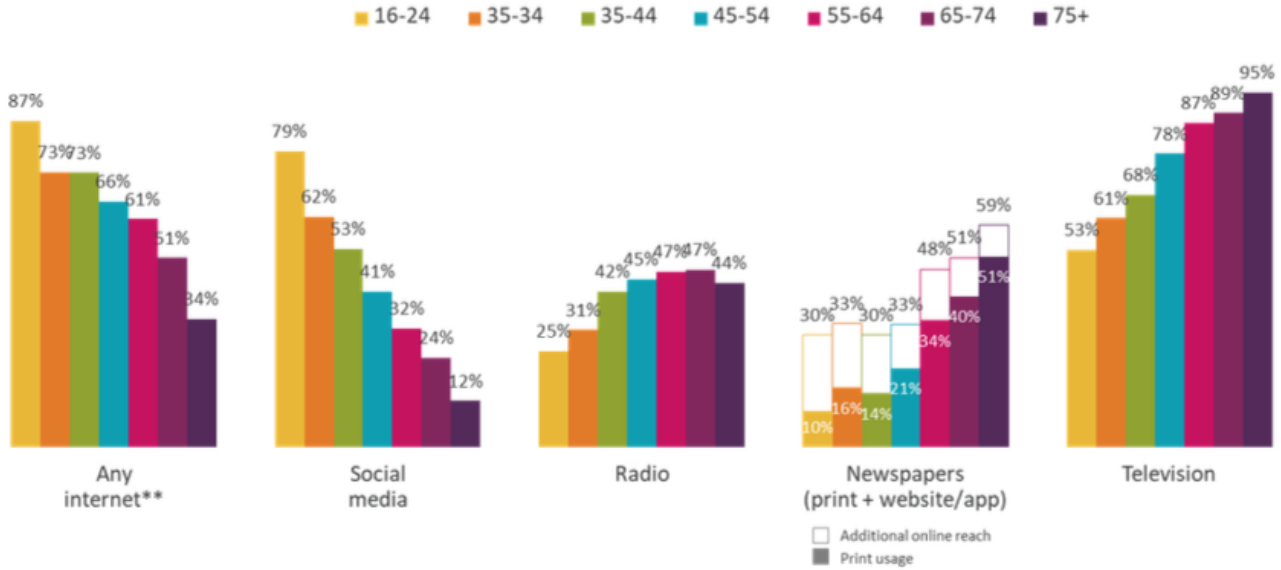
Younger age groups are more likely to use the internet and social media for news. Reach of newspapers doubles for groups aged 16-44 when online newspapers are included

Ofcom
making communications work for everyone

Figure 2.5

Use of main platforms for news nowadays 2022* – by age

All adults 16+



Source: Ofcom News Consumption Survey 2022 – COMBINED F2F & ONLINE sample
Question: C1. Which of the following platforms do you use for news nowadays?
Base: All Adults 16+ 2022 W2* – Aged 16-24=442, 25-34=385, 35-44=520, 45-54=463, 55-64=412, 65-74=346, 75+=223
*2022 W1 data not shown because face-to-face fieldwork was not possible during Covid-19 pandemic
**Internet figures include use of social media, podcasts and all other websites/apps accessed via any device

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Trust in News in the UK

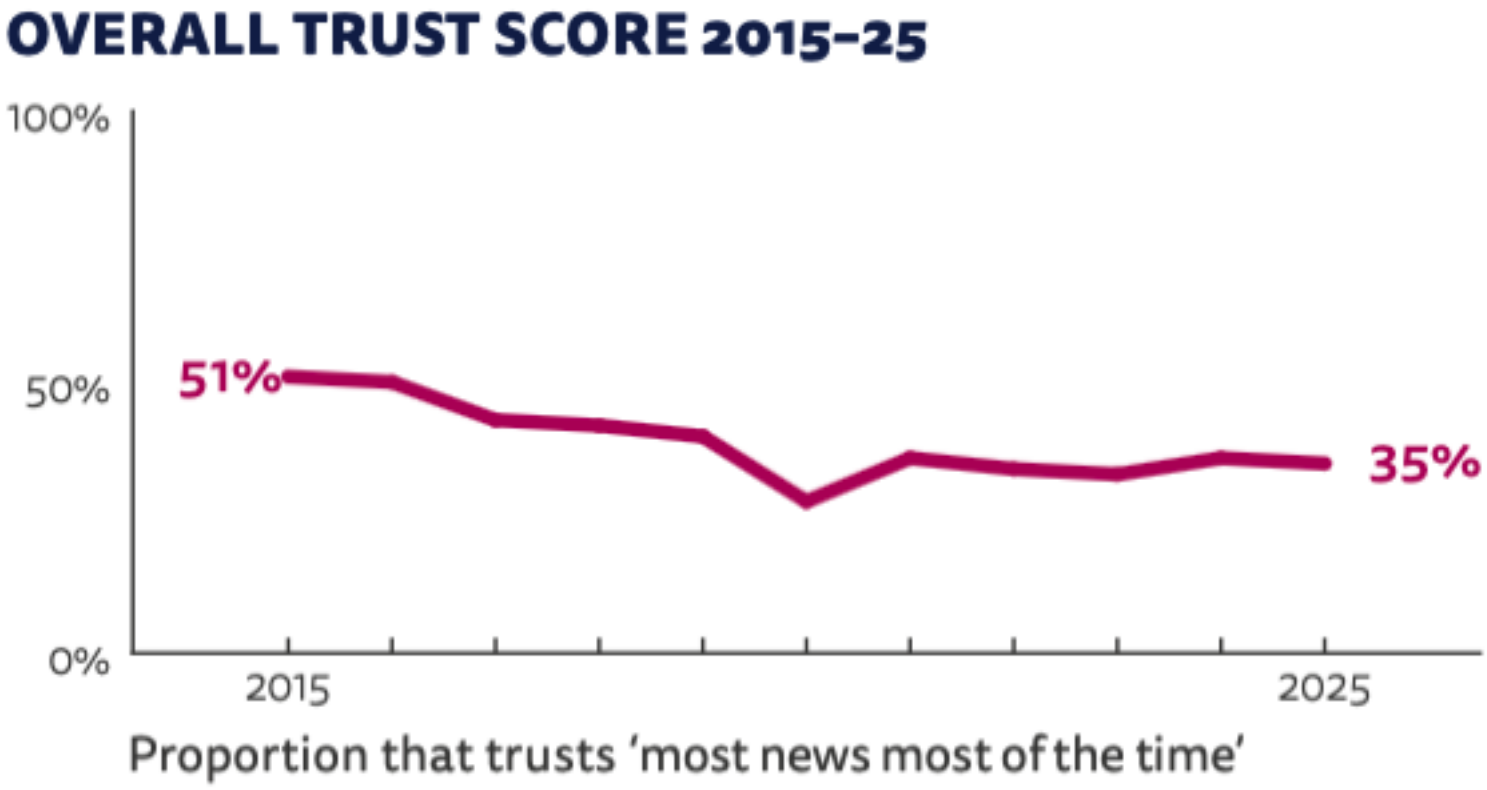


Figure: Newman et al., 2025

Recent Research



My Research

Research

In Progress

1. Jarnach, C. 'Beyond Polarity: Paucity, Promiscuity, and Public Service in Online News Consumption in the Brexit Campaign'. (*Available on request*).
2. Jarnach, C. 'Mapping the AI Elite: Networks, Inequality, and Power Concentration among Unelected Governors of AI'.

Under Peer Review

1. Jarnach, C., 'Media made me do it?! Assessing the Effect of Various News Sources on Brexit Voting', (Under peer review at *International Journal of Public Opinion Research*)
2. Jarnach, C., 'Forming Brexit Identities: The Impact of News Media on Political Identity Change', (Under peer review at *British Journal of Political Science*)
3. Jarnach, C., 'Political Chatter: Investigating Effects of Interpersonal Influence and Mass Media on Brexit Identity Strength'. (Under peer review at *Political Communication*).

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Paper 1

PAPER 1 – Research Question

Does digital news consumption exhibit signs of political polarisation?

PAPER 1 – Hypothesis

Individuals will seek out political information and media outlets that confirm rather than disconfirm their political stances.

PAPER 1 – Approach

Analysing browsing history as two-mode network of UK individuals and online news websites.

PAPER 1 – Data

Combination of

- clickstream data
- survey data

PAPER 1 – Method

- Descriptive & inferential statistics
- Network analysis

PAPER 1 – Method

- Rule-based classification on article URLs
- Two-mode audience network analysis (direct and projected)
- Marginal likelihood edge filter

PAPER 1 – Clickstream Data

All News:

- 30,084 user–article observations
- 16,023 URLs
- 306 domains

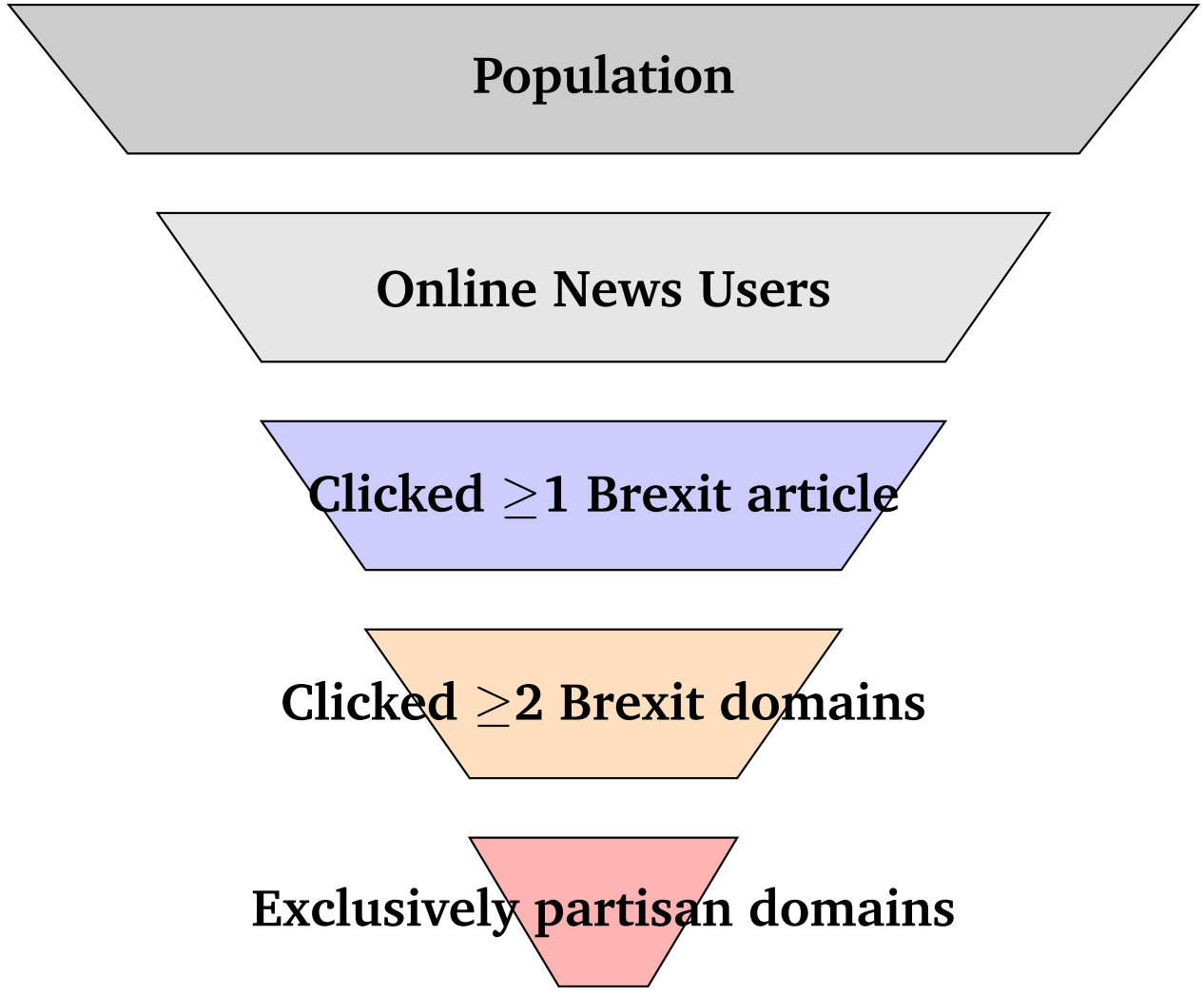
PAPER 1 – Brexit Only News:

- 969 URLs
- 75 domains

PAPER 1 – Clickstream Data Sample

CS Data Sample	N	(%)
In Clickstream Data	959	100%
News Domain Clickers	672	70%
EU Referendum News Clickers	256	27%

How Much Brexit News Did People Actually See?



PAPER 1 – Takeaway so far

- **Political exposure was rare.**
- **Even rarer was exclusive partisan exposure.**

PAPER 1 – Consumption of political news is low

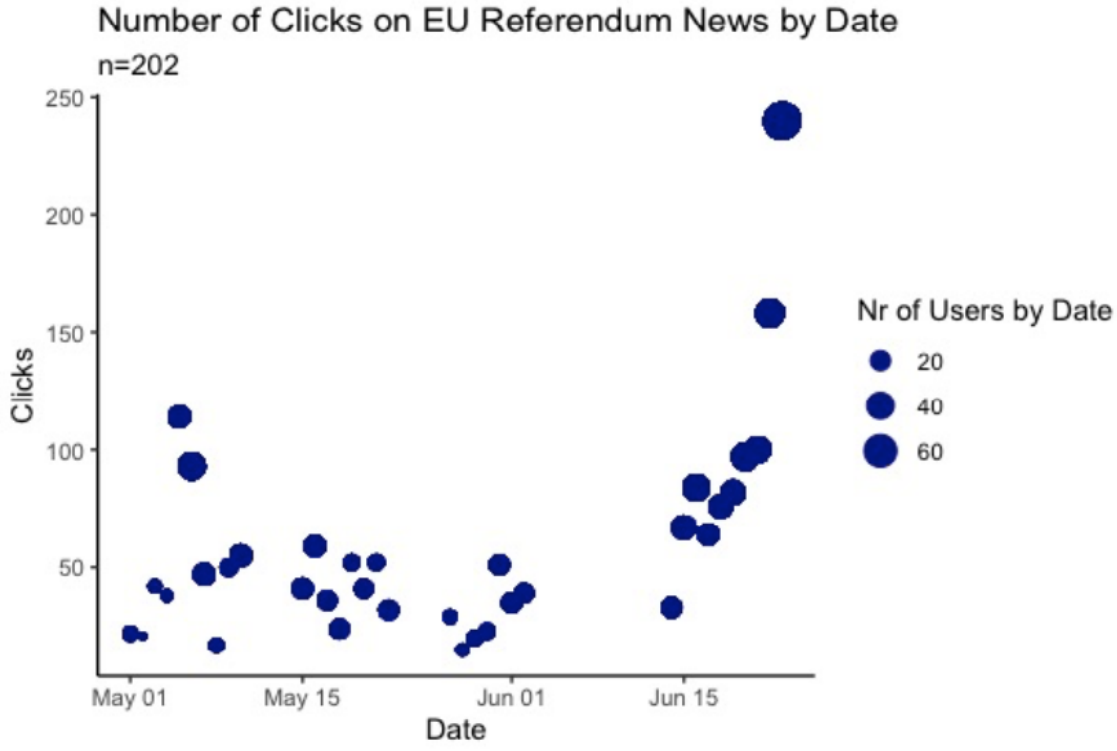


Figure 3 Number of Clicks on EU Referendum News by Date.
Note: The clickstream collection period starting on 1 May to 23 June has gaps in the data from the 11 to 14 May, 23 to 26 May, and 3 to 13 June.

PAPER 1 – Clicks on Brexit News Online

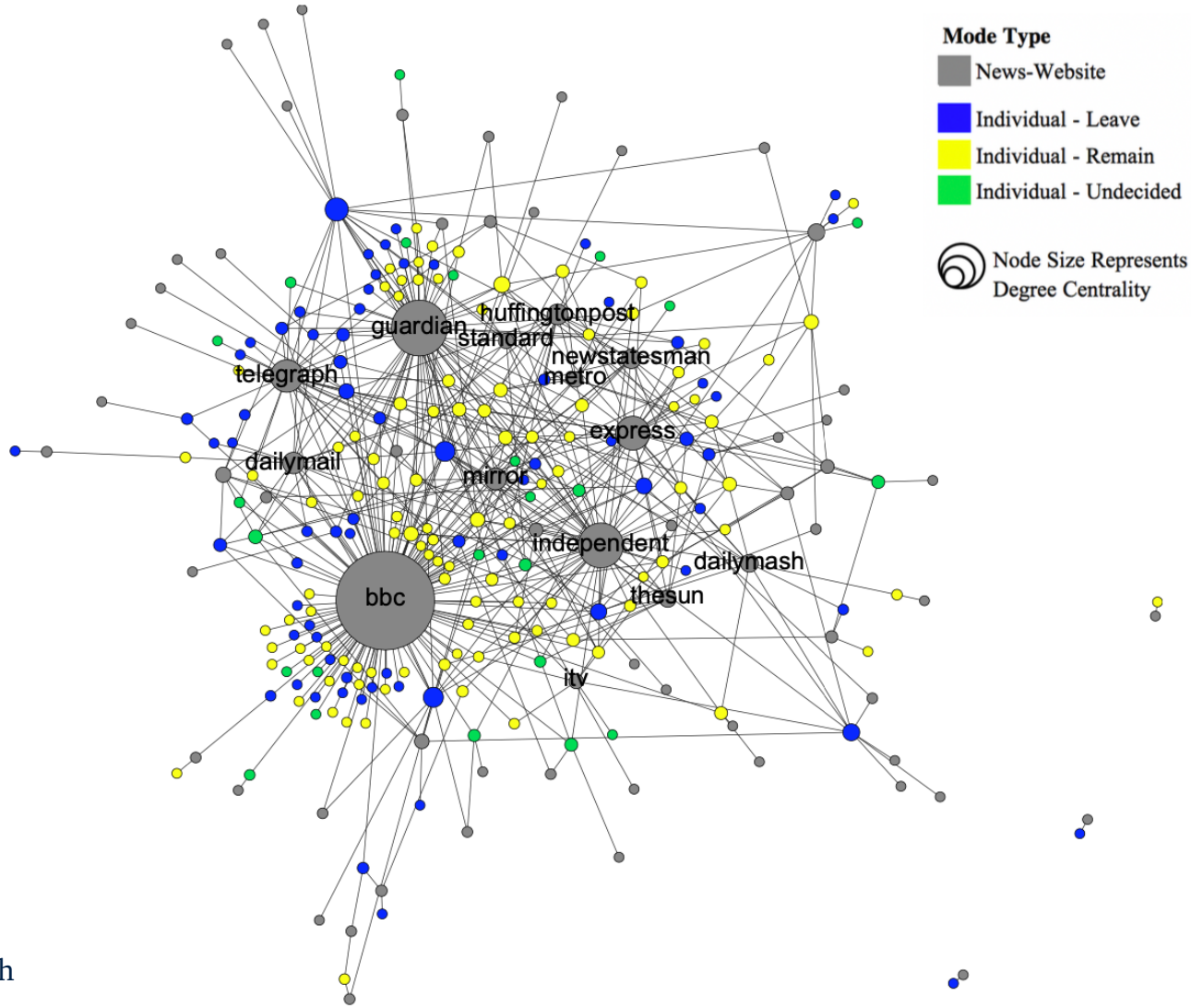
Table 2: Negative Binomial Model

	Dependent variable:	
	Nr. of Clicks	
	(1) Full Sample	(2) Super-Readers Excluded
Remain (ref. = Leave)	-0.382^{**}	0.035
	(0.179)	(0.142)
Undecided	-1.394^{***}	-0.688^{***}
	(0.292)	(0.231)
Constant	2.610^{***}	1.904^{***}
	(0.137)	(0.110)
Observations	202	197
Log Likelihood	−664.194	−570.801
θ	0.772^{***} (0.073)	1.434^{***} (0.168)
Akaike Inf. Crit.	1,334.389	1,147.602
Note:		*p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01

Figure: Jarnach, forthcoming

PAPER 1 – Online Audience Network of Brexit News

Figure 14 Audience Network – Two-Mode
Nodes = 277 (i.e. Individuals = 202; Domains = 75) Layout: Forced Atlas



PAPER 1 – Domain choice by referendum vote

Table 2.5: Mixed-Effects Logistic Regression Analysis of Domain Choice

	Dependent variable: Domain Choice									
	BBC		Guardian		Independent		Express		Telegraph	
	Coef.	SE	Coef.	SE	Coef.	SE	Coef.	SE	Coef.	SE
EU-Ref. Attitudes fixed effects (reference = Remain)										
Leave	−1.132 **	(0.571)	−0.619	(0.643)	−1.270 ***	(0.469)	2.109 ***	(0.785)	1.796 **	(0.701)
Undecided	−1.492 *	(0.888)	−0.903	(1.075)	−0.988	(0.819)	1.825	(1.151)	1.499	(1.088)
Intercept	−0.564	(0.354)	−3.355 ***	(0.479)	−3.154 ***	(0.295)	−6.385 ***	(0.825)	−6.033 ***	(0.747)
Variance of random effects										
Intercept (Std.Dev.)	9.409	(3.067)	9.236	(3.039)	2.419	(1.555)	9.001	(3.000)	6.916	(2.63)
Observations (i.e. Clicks)	2,049		2,049		2,049		2,049		2,049	
Clusters (i.e. Users)	202		202		202		202		202	
Log Likelihood	−769.54		−467.03		−334.57		−313.45		−295.13	
AIC	1,547.08		942.06		677.14		634.91		598.25	

Note: *p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01

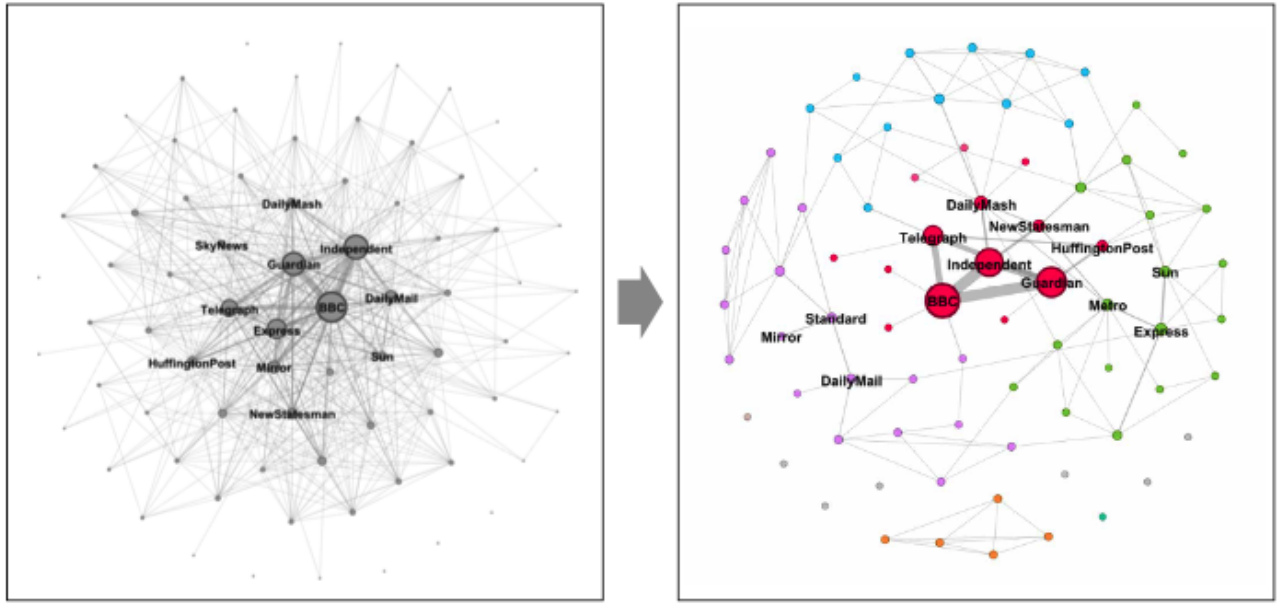
Table (Continued)

	Daily Mail		Mirror		Huffington Post		New Statesman	
	Coef.	SE	Coef.	SE	Coef.	SE	Coef.	SE
EU-Ref. Attitudes fixed effects (reference = Remain)								
Leave	1.623 *	(0.926)	−0.008	(0.947)	−0.390	(0.715)	−1.461	(1.035)
Undecided	1.733	(1.333)	2.124 *	(1.256)	0.093	(1.252)	−0.225	(1.524)
Intercept	−7.495 ***	(1.173)	−7.056 ***	(1.160)	−5.487 ***	(0.726)	−6.392 ***	(1.015)
Variance of random effects								
Intercept (Std.Dev.)	7.789	(2.791)	8.580	(2.929)	2.796	(1.672)	7.089	(2.662)
Observations (i.e. Clicks)	2,049		2,049		2,049		2,049	
Clusters (i.e. Users)	202		202		202		202	
Log Likelihood	−143.75		−177.23		−97.37		−111.24	
AIC	295.51		362.45		202.74		230.48	

Note: *p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01

PAPER 1 – Co-Domain Projection

Figure 2.7: Co-Domain Projection Model Visualised as Simple Projection (SP) and as Pruned Projection (PP). Node Size Indicates Degree Centrality; All Nodes Represent News Domains

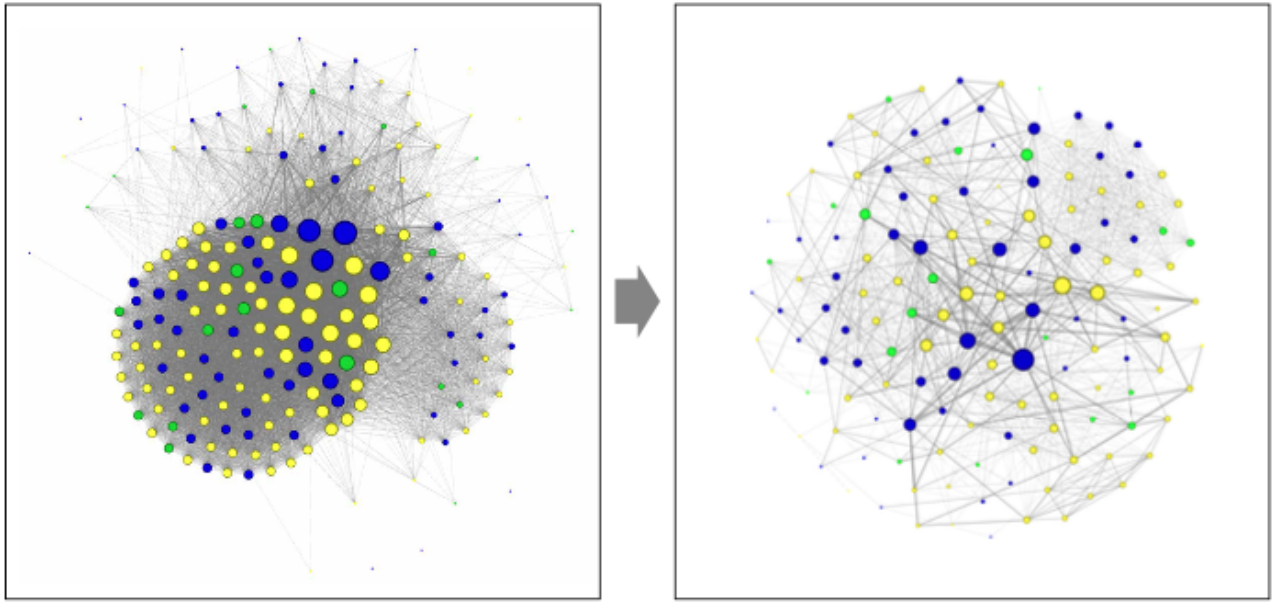


(a) Co-Domain Simple Projection (SP) Retaining All Information

(b) Pruned Projection using Marginal Likelihood Filter (MLF) method; the top 25% of the edges are retained. Colours represent community membership.

PAPER 1 – Co-Individual Projection

Figure 2.8: Co-Individual Projection Model Visualised as Simple Projection (SP) and as Pruned Projection (PP). Node Size Indicates Degree Centrality; Blue = Leave Supporters, Yellow = Remain Supporters, Green = Undecided



(a) Co-Individual Simple Projection (SP) Retaining All Information

(b) Pruned Projection using Marginal Likelihood Filter (MLF), the top 15% of the edges are retained

PAPER 1 – Summary of Findings

1. **Methodological Contribution**
   - Behavioural evidence from *browsing history data*
   - Moves beyond self-reports and social media trace data

2. **Empirical Pattern of Online News Consumption**
   - Echo chambers were not highly predominant
   - Two dominant user types emerged:
     1. Low or no engagement with Brexit-related news
     2. Selective but *diverse* consumers (”promiscuous” news use)

3. **Where Does One-Sided Exposure Come From?**
   - Risk concentrated among **news-apathetic** individuals
   - The **BBC** functioned as a central reference point:
     - Used by more than half of online news users
     - Over one-third of all Brexit-related clicks

Paper 2

PAPER 2 – What Strengthened Brexit Identities?

Context

- After the 2016 EU Referendum, 89% identified as *Leavers* or *Remainers*
- Switching identities was rare
- The key question: *What drove identity entrenchment?*

Research Design

- Representative panel data (British Election Study)
- 2016 Referendum, 2017 and 2019 General Elections
- Longitudinal mixed-effects models
- Outcome variable: Change in **strength** of Brexit identity

PAPER 2 – Data

Data Source

- British Election Study (BES) Internet Panel
- YouGov-administered, nationally representative sample
- Three electoral periods analysed:
  - 2016 EU Referendum
  - 2017 General Election
  - 2019 General Election

PAPER 2 – Methods

Research Design

- Three waves per electoral event:
  - Pre-campaign
  - Campaign
  - Post-election
- Quasi-experimental One-Group Pretest–Posttest design
- Longitudinal model with individual random effect (baseline ID-Index) and time fixed effect
- Linear mixed-effects estimation

PAPER 2 – Methods

Key Measures

Brexit Identity Classification

- Self-reported Leave vs Remain identification

Brexit Identity Strength Index

- Four-item scale capturing:
  - Use of “we” language
  - Emotional offence when criticised
  - Felt connection to co-supporters
  - Positive affect when praised

PAPER 2 – Brexit identity share & average strength

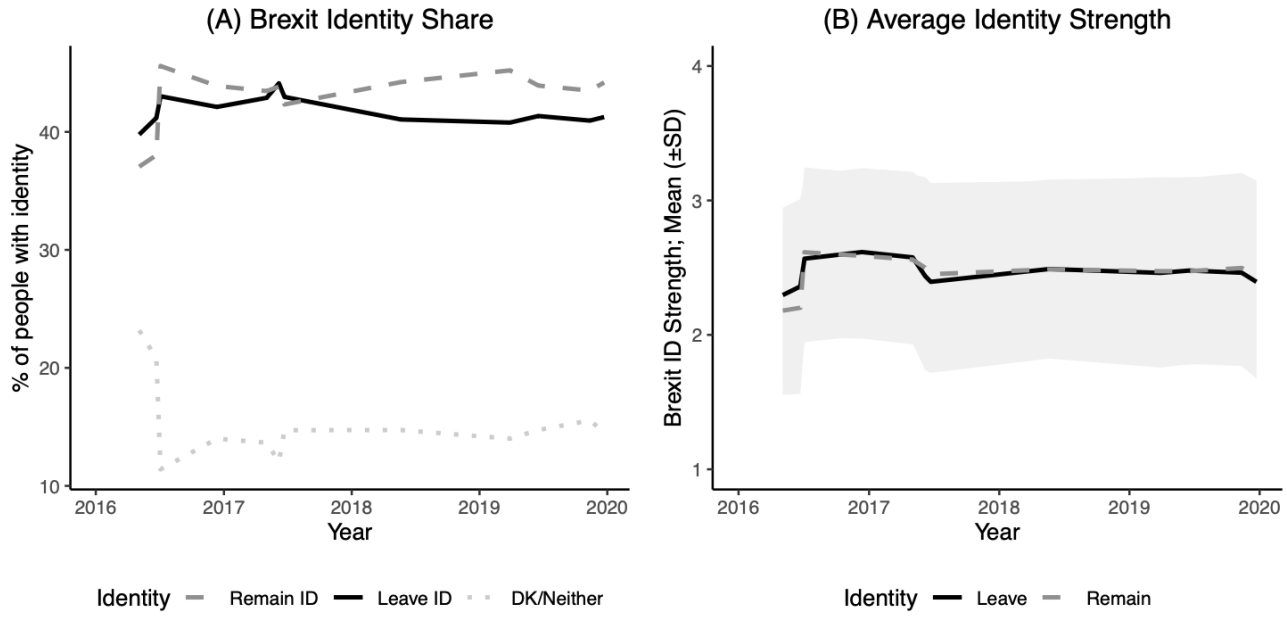


Figure 5.3: Brexit identity share and average strength. Figure A illustrates the percentage of the British electorate identifying as closer to either the 'Leave' or 'Remain' side. Figure B depicts the average strength of Brexit identity among 'Leave' and 'Remain' identifiers, with the grey shaded area representing ±1 standard deviation from the mean. Data are sourced from the British Election Study (BES), with samples weighted to reflect the British population.

PAPER 2 – Leave ID Strength

Table 5.3: Effects of Political News Exposure on Leave ID Strength - Results from Linear Mixed Effects Models

	Dependent variable: Leave ID Strength		
	(1)	(2)	(3)
	2016 EU Ref.	2017 GE	2019 GE
FIXED EFFECTS			
Internet (ref. = None)			
0<1h	−0.008 (0.017)	0.017* (0.008)	0.010 (0.015)
>1h	−0.009 (0.024)	0.045*** (0.013)	−0.013 (0.022)
TV (ref. = None)			
0<1h	0.010 (0.029)	0.017 (0.010)	−0.001 (0.017)
>1h	0.021 (0.031)	0.023 (0.012)	−0.003 (0.021)
Newspaper (ref. = None)			
0<1h	−0.128 (0.075)	−0.037 (0.035)	0.016 (0.069)
>1h	−0.104 (0.084)	0.048 (0.046)	0.076 (0.090)
Newspaper Stance			
(ref.= Remain Paper)			
Leave Paper	−0.126 (0.076)	−0.024 (0.030)	−0.021 (0.056)
Unclassifiable Papers	−0.175 (0.092)	−0.025 (0.034)	0.024 (0.064)
No Preferred Paper	−0.145* (0.072)	−0.029 (0.029)	−0.002 (0.053)
Newspaper * Newspaper Stance			
(ref.= None*Remain Paper)			
0<1h * Leave Paper	0.162* (0.081)	0.065 (0.037)	0.034 (0.073)
>1h * Leave Paper	0.132 (0.090)	−0.036 (0.048)	0.009 (0.094)
0<1h * Unclassifiable Papers	0.151 (0.100)	0.034 (0.042)	−0.052 (0.082)
>1h * Unclassifiable Papers	0.167 (0.110)	−0.024 (0.056)	−0.008 (0.106)
0<1h * No Preferred Paper	0.137 (0.081)	0.062 (0.037)	−0.009 (0.072)
>1h * No Preferred Paper	0.171 (0.095)	−0.060 (0.052)	0.001 (0.104)
Radio (ref. = None)			
0<1h	−0.020 (0.016)	−0.013 (0.008)	0.026 (0.015)
>1h	−0.006 (0.022)	−0.007 (0.014)	0.012 (0.024)
People (ref. = None)			
0<1h	0.069** (0.023)	0.038*** (0.009)	
>1h	0.128*** (0.030)	0.052*** (0.014)	
Pre Treatment Leave ID Strength	0.743*** (0.012)	0.823*** (0.006)	0.861*** (0.010)
Intercept	0.756*** (0.143)	0.465*** (0.040)	0.376*** (0.068)
RANDOM EFFECTS Variance (Std.Dev.)			
Individual Intercept	0.029 (0.169)	0.020 (0.142)	0.008 (0.089)
Residual	0.115 (0.339)	0.107 (0.327)	0.102 (0.320)
Observations	5,312	14,845	3,708
R^2	0.71	0.74	0.79
Log Likelihood	−3,390.181	−7,898.518	−1,708.274

Notes: *p<0.05; **p<0.01; ***p<0.001. Source: British Election Study Internet Panel Waves 7-9, 11-13, 17-19. Dependent variable: Leave Identity Strength Index; Cell entries for fixed effects are coefficients, with associated standard errors in parentheses; entries for random effects represent variance and associated standard deviation in parentheses. Although the coefficients for some controls are not shown in this table, all models include controls for age, sex, education (No cert., GCSE, A-level, degree, DK), employment status (full-time, part-time, student, retired, unemployed, other), household income (as a factor variable with DK and and refusals as separate categories), seven-point British and European identity scales, party identity, and political attention. Pre-treatment Brexit identity and survey waves are included as time fixed effects.

PAPER 2 – Remain ID Strength

Table 5.4: Effects of Political News Exposure on Remain ID Strength - Results from Linear Mixed Effects Models

	Dependent variable: Remain ID Strength		
	(1)	(2)	(3)
	2016 EU Ref.	2017 GE	2019 GE
FIXED EFFECTS			
Internet (ref. = None)			
0<1h	0.021 (0.022)	0.010 (0.009)	0.002 (0.016)
>1h	0.024 (0.028)	0.007 (0.011)	0.019 (0.022)
TV (ref. = None)			
0<1h	−0.003 (0.024)	−0.006 (0.009)	−0.017 (0.017)
>1h	0.010 (0.027)	−0.005 (0.012)	−0.017 (0.021)
Newspaper (ref. = None)			
0<1h	0.056 (0.050)	0.018 (0.020)	0.009 (0.038)
>1h	0.009 (0.055)	0.017 (0.022)	0.028 (0.042)
Newspaper Stance			
(ref.= Remain Paper)			
Leave Paper	0.028 (0.064)	−0.055* (0.025)	−0.030 (0.050)
Unclassifiable Papers	0.063 (0.065)	0.002 (0.025)	−0.005 (0.048)
No Preferred Paper	0.006 (0.049)	−0.023 (0.019)	−0.024 (0.036)
Newspaper * Newspaper Stance			
(ref.= None*Remain Paper)			
0<1h * Leave Paper	−0.075 (0.070)	0.042 (0.029)	0.027 (0.057)
>1h * Leave Paper	−0.001 (0.085)	0.028 (0.038)	0.038 (0.073)
0<1h * Unclassifiable Papers	−0.084 (0.070)	−0.018 (0.028)	−0.017 (0.055)
>1h * Unclassifiable Papers	0.058 (0.077)	−0.006 (0.033)	−0.021 (0.065)
0<1h * No Preferred Paper	0.005 (0.056)	0.017 (0.023)	−0.001 (0.043)
>1h * No Preferred Paper	0.051 (0.074)	0.012 (0.031)	−0.062 (0.055)
Radio (ref. = None)			
0<1h	0.015 (0.018)	0.022** (0.008)	0.022 (0.014)
>1h	−0.019 (0.026)	0.024* (0.012)	0.0001 (0.021)
People (ref. = None)			
0<1h	0.037 (0.024)	0.056*** (0.011)	
>1h	0.066* (0.033)	0.070*** (0.014)	
Pre Treatment Leave ID Strength	0.756*** (0.013)	0.834*** (0.006)	0.870*** (0.009)
Intercept	0.412*** (0.113)	0.325*** (0.037)	0.339*** (0.066)
RANDOM EFFECTS Variance (Std.Dev.)			
Individual Intercept	0.028 (0.169)	0.020 (0.142)	0.010 (0.098)
Residual	0.128 (0.357)	0.095 (0.309)	0.095 (0.308)
Observations	4,977	15,292	3,451
R^2	0.69	0.77	0.81
Log Likelihood	−3,593.391	−8,041.462	−1,431.237

Notes: *p<0.05; **p<0.01; ***p<0.001. Source: British Election Study Internet Panel Waves 7-9, 11-13, 17-19. Dependent variable: Leave Identity Strength Index; Cell entries for fixed effects are coefficients, with associated standard errors in parentheses; entries for random effects represent variance and associated standard deviation in parentheses. Although the coefficients for some controls are not shown in this table, all models include controls for age, sex, education (No cert., GCSE, A-level, degree, DK), employment status (full-time, part-time, student, retired, unemployed, other), household income (as a factor variable with DK and and refusals as separate categories), seven-point British and European identity scales, party identity, and political attention. Pre-treatment Brexit identity and survey waves are included as time fixed effects.

PAPER 2 – Predicted ID Strength

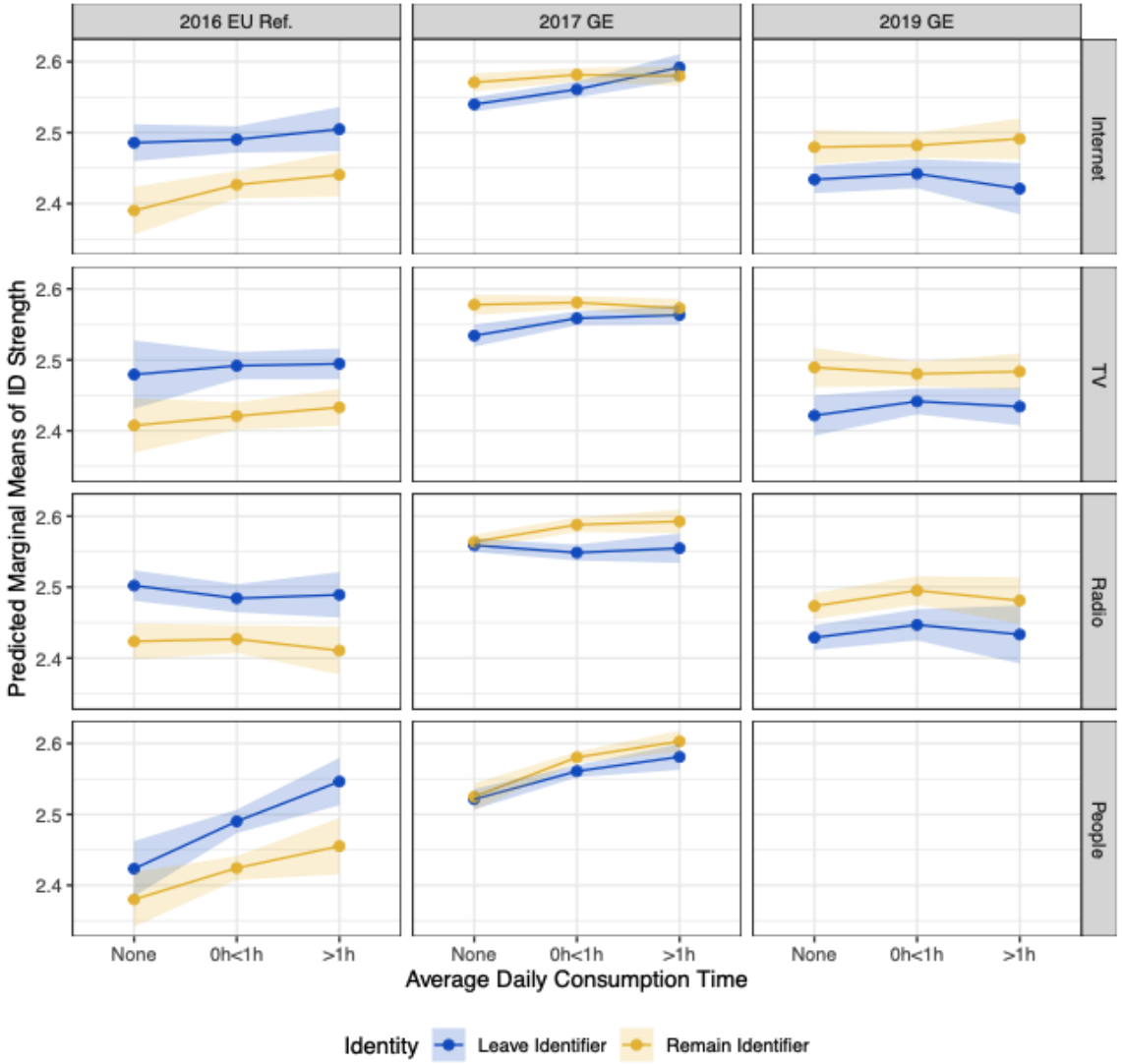


Figure 5.5: Predicted Identity Strength by News Source

PAPER 2 – Mass Media & Interpersonal Communication

Table 5.5: Effects of Mass Media Exposure and Political Interpersonal Communication - Results from Linear Mixed Effects Models

	Dependent variable:			
	Leave ID Strength	Leave ID Strength	Remain ID Strength	Remain ID Strength
	2016 EU Ref.	2017 GE	2016 EU Ref.	2017 GE
FIXED EFFECTS				
Political News Exposure through (ref. = None)				
Mass Media & Interpersonal Communication	0.130* (0.061)	0.060*** (0.014)	0.0004 (0.056)	0.068*** (0.017)
Only Mass Media	0.058 (0.063)	0.019 (0.015)	−0.057 (0.058)	−0.004 (0.019)
Only Interpersonal Communication	0.015 (0.113)	0.038* (0.017)	0.060 (0.098)	0.017 (0.020)
Pre Treatment Leave ID Strength	0.751*** (0.012)	0.823*** (0.006)	0.754*** (0.013)	0.834*** (0.006)
Intercept	0.563*** (0.126)	0.438*** (0.029)	0.440*** (0.108)	0.310*** (0.034)
RANDOM EFFECTS				
Variance (Std.Dev.)				
Individual Intercept	0.029 (0.170)	0.021 (0.142)	0.029 (0.170)	0.021 (0.144)
Residual	0.115 (0.340)	0.108 (0.328)	0.127 (0.357)	0.098 (0.314)
Observations	5,416	15,330	5,055	15,799
R^2	0.70	0.74	0.69	0.76
Log Likelihood	−3,432.074	−8,195.536	−3,617.386	−8,460.442

Notes: *p<0.05; **p<0.01; ***p<0.001. Source: British Election Study Internet Panel Waves 7-9, 11-13. Cell entries for fixed effects are coefficients, with associated standard errors in parentheses; entries for random effects represent variance and associated standard deviation in parentheses. Although the coefficients for some controls are not shown in this table, all models include controls for age, sex, education (No cert., GCSE, A-level, degree, DK), employment status (full-time, part-time, student, retired, unemployed, other), household income (as a factor variable with DK and and refusals as separate categories), seven-point British and European identity scales, party identity, and political attention. Pre-treatment Brexit identity and survey waves are included as time fixed effects.

PAPER 2 – Findings

Brexit identities were socially reinforced more than media-driven.

- **Interpersonal communication** was the primary driver of identity reinforcement
- Effect observed for both Leavers and Remainers
- Three-quarters reported interpersonal communication as a regular political information source
- **Mass media played a limited, supportive role**

Questions

Q & A

Discussion

- “When exposure is jointly produced by psychology, supply, and algorithms, how should we conceptualise influence?”
- “If persuasion is limited, but identity reinforcement is strong, what does this imply for theories of media effects and misinformation?”
- “If identities drive belief and behaviour, where should interventions target?”
- “Are we overestimating echo chambers and underestimating apathy?”

Contact

Thank you!

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